J.W. Couch Education: Teachers Grant

Due March 28, 2025

Priority Area (Teachers): *Teachers are essential to providing children with the best possible education. We must invest in their future and are always looking for teams that help them succeed in educating future generations.*

Grant Plans:

Support from the J.W. Couch Foundation would catalyze the expansion of Hanna Institute's trauma-responsive teacher training and contribute to our evolution as a national research and innovation hub. Hanna Institute, a program of Hanna Center, has already laid strong groundwork by equipping educators—through partnerships with Head Start California, the Sonoma County Office of Education, and others—with the tools to foster compassionate, resilient schools.

To build on this momentum, Hanna Institute is codifying a structured and replicable trauma-responsive model, which will be piloted with key partners and integrated into our HannaHow online learning platform. Philanthropic support will accelerate this work and ensure wider access to trauma-informed educational leadership training rooted in real-world application.

Aligned with our strategic priorities, future funding will also support academic partnerships and rigorous research efforts. Hanna is currently formalizing collaborations with universities such as San Diego State University to evaluate the effectiveness of trauma-responsive interventions and publish peer-reviewed research. This will culminate in the publication of Hanna's first white paper and the development of graduate-level coursework and fellowships to nurture the next generation of leaders in trauma-informed care.

By investing in this work, the J.W. Couch Foundation would help strengthen an evidence-based, scalable framework for trauma-responsive education—and position Hanna Institute as a national leader in advancing healing-centered learning environments across the country.

Project Name: Building Resilience in Classrooms: Expanding Trauma-Responsive Training for Educators

Project Summary

Hanna Institute seeks funding to expand its trauma-responsive training program for educators, empowering them to create restorative, supportive classroom environments that promote healing and growth for students affected by trauma.

The COVID-19 pandemic significantly heightened the prevalence of trauma and mental health challenges among students, underscoring the urgent need for trauma-responsive training programs for educators. Recent data and studies reveal a critical escalation in mental health issues among youth in the current climate. A 2023 survey by the American Psychological Association indicates that long-term stress since the pandemic's onset has notably impacted well-being, with a significant rise in mental health conditions. Additional data on youth health and wellness demonstrates surges in depression and anxiety affecting approximately 25% of youth, persistent feelings of sadness or hopelessness in over 44% of adolescents, increased suicidal considerations in nearly 20% of high school students, and a rise in absenteeism from school.

By extending our training to an additional 500 educators, we aim to increase the impact of trauma-informed practices across K-12 schools, providing teachers with the tools and skills to respond to students' emotional needs and create a safe, inclusive space for learning.

Project Objectives

1. **Reach 500 additional educators:** Through targeted outreach and engagement, we aim to train 500 more educators in trauma-responsive teaching practices, bringing the total number of trained educators to over 1,500.
2. **Expand restorative practices in classrooms:** Equip educators with practical tools to implement restorative practices, allowing students to build empathy, accountability, and resilience within their school communities.
3. **Build community and support networks for educators:** Foster peer-to-peer learning and ongoing support through mentorship opportunities, creating a sustainable network of educators committed to trauma-responsive approaches.
4. **Measure impact and effectiveness:** Develop tools for assessing the outcomes of the training and the long-term effects on student well-being, teacher effectiveness, and classroom culture.

Funding Amount Requested: $100,000

Budget Timetable: July 1, 2025 - June 30, 2026

- **Phase 1**:
  - $50,000 for curriculum development, adaptation and customization, and program delivery
  - $10,000 for outreach, marketing, and recruitment of participants
- **Phase 2**
  - $25,000 for facilitator fees and administrative costs
- **Phase 3**
  - $15,000 for evaluation and assessment tools

More Details

Following the pandemic, educators experienced some of the highest levels of stress and burnout in the U.S. according to a recent Gallup poll. At the same time, we saw children increasingly experience stress and trauma, which can significantly impair various aspects of their development. These stress responses impede executive functioning, emotional regulation, impulsivity, communication, and attention and can adversely affect classroom behavior and peer relationships. Researchers have found trauma-responsive training helps teachers better address their students' growth and development *and* provides tools for their own self-regulation and adult stress response. These trainings are an additional tool to combat teacher burnout and turnover– a crisis in education, especially in low-income school districts and Special Education departments. The investment in trauma-informed education therefore supports the health, well-being, and growth of both educators and their students.

Hanna Institute has a proven track record of success, having already trained over 1,000 educators in trauma-responsive practices including connection, deescalation, and avoiding overcorrection all with a trauma-informed lens. This funding will allow us to scale the program, ensuring that more educators are equipped with skills to meet the emotional and academic needs of their students. With the support of the J.W. Couch Foundation, we will provide comprehensive training, long-term support, and a pathway for educators to transform their classrooms into environments that support resilience and healing.

Attachments

- IRS Determination letter
- Relevant Grant Request Budgets

- Most recent 990
- Annual Operational Budgets